

Post-incident review PIR-2026-048

Order Management: failed sign-ins

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 25 February 2026, Order Management experienced failed sign-ins in production (US West) for about 75 minutes. A latency threshold alert fired for the service's main endpoint. Investigation found that a retry loop without backoff multiplied the load on a struggling downstream call.

Impact

Users of Order Management saw failed sign-ins for about 75 minutes. The service owner, Commerce Platform, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:18 First signal received.
- 09:34 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:41 Likely cause identified.
- 10:08 Mitigation applied.
- 10:52 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that a retry loop without backoff multiplied the load on a struggling downstream call.

Certificates were checked as part of triage and were valid.

There was no documented procedure for this failure mode, so responders worked it out live.

The relevant alert had fired repeatedly the previous week and had been muted by the on-call engineer.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Write and rehearse a runbook for this failure mode.
- Assign a named owner for the component in the service catalogue.
- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.